

Radio Caroline: The Pirate Radio [B1]

Fondata nel 1964 per contrastare il monopolio della BBC, l'emittente continua ad andare in onda nonostante tempeste, naufragi, mancanza di fondi e persino attacchi armati.



It's hard to believe, given the wide choice of music available today, that the BBC held a monopoly on UK radio broadcasting until 1973. Celebrating its sixtieth anniversary this year, Radio Caroline was the first of a new wave of pirate radio stations to challenge and disrupt the state-owned service

READY TO ROCK

In the early 1960s, as rock music exploded across the [airwaves](#), the BBC [allocated](#) just six hours a week to popular music on its UK network. The only competition came from Radio Luxembourg, which played hits from the major [record labels](#). But how could anyone hear new, independent artists?

OFFSHORE

In 1961, Ronan O'Rahilly, an Irish entrepreneur, arrived in London full of ideas for music promotion. He decided to set up his own radio station, on a boat, knowing that the British broadcasting laws only extended to a three-mile limit [offshore](#). O'Rahilly named his new station Radio Caroline, after the daughter of US President John F. Kennedy.

ANCHORED

Together with businessman Alan Crawford, O'Rahilly prepared two ships for broadcasting. On 28 March 1964, the [off the Suffolk coast](#) MV Caroline anchored legally in international waters and announced: "This is Radio Caroline on 199, your all day music station". Radio Caroline was on air...

PIRATES

By autumn that year, Radio Caroline had seven million listeners. Inspired by O'Rahilly's example, other pirate radio stations took to the [airwaves](#). The British government quickly introduced new legislation [to outlaw](#) the stations, which were forced to close. Radio Caroline went [off air](#) for several years but was relaunched in the early 1970s.

LOVING AWARENESS

With its eclectic mix of album tracks and concept of [Loving Awareness](#), a form of peaceful [eastern](#) philosophy promoted by O'Rahilly, Radio Caroline had a strong new identity. Through the following decades, thanks to O'Rahilly, the [crew](#), DJs and supporters, Radio Caroline stayed on air [despite](#) storms, an armed [raid](#) by Dutch and British officials, [breakdowns](#), a [sinking](#), and, always, a lack of money.

When Ronan O'Rahilly died in April 2020, he left a lasting legacy: Radio Caroline was an act of musical rebellion, a philosophy, and a family of broadcast pioneers remaining on air [against all the odds](#).

Glossary

- **airwaves** = onde radio
- **took to the airwaves** = andare in onda
- **eastern** = orientale
- **crew** = squadra
- **sinking** = affondamento
- **record labels** = etichette discografiche
- **off the Suffolk coast** MV = imbarcazione a motore (motor vessel)
- **raid** = incursione
- **allocated** = assegnare
- **offshore** = al largo, in alto mare
- **off the Suffolk coast** = al largo della costa
- **to outlaw** = dichiarare fuori legge
- **off air** = non trasmettere più
- **despite** = nonostante
- **Loving Awareness** = Amanti della conoscenza
- **breakdowns** = guasti
- **against all the odds** = contro ogni previsione